

« Indian hockey is alive because of heritage tournaments »

DILIP TIRKEY

Y. B. Sarangi
sarangi.y@thehindu.co.in

As Indian hockey marks a century since the formation of the Indian Hockey Federation (IHF) in 1925, Hockey India (HI) — which later succeeded the IHF — is reflecting not only on the sport's illustrious past but also on new ways to elevate its standard in the country.

Coincidentally, as Indian hockey reaches this milestone, the federation is headed by three-time Olympian and former India captain Dilip Tirkey. *Sportstar* spoke to Tirkey — who also served as president when India retained its bronze medal at the Paris 2024 Olympics — to discuss the challenges ahead and HI's vision for the future.

Indian hockey is celebrating its 100-year journey. How do you see this?

A lot of effort went into the

formation of the IHF in the 1920s. Over the last century, Indian hockey has given a lot to the country. Our national teams have won gold medals at the 1928, 1932, 1936, 1948, 1952, 1956, 1964 and 1980 Olympics.

They have also won medals in other important events such as the World Cup, the Asian Games, the Commonwealth Games and the Asia Cup.

Post 1980, our performance declined — we couldn't even qualify for the 2008 Olympics. But in 2020 and 2024, we won Olympic bronze medals.

How do you envision the future of HI?

We need to keep global developments in hockey in mind and move forward with our plans. Around 15–20 years ago, Holland, Germany and Australia were among the top teams. Now, countries like

Belgium and Spain are doing well. We need to lift our coaching standards and strengthen the Hockey India League (HIL), which has been a great platform for young players.

We also need to identify good coaches. In our country, good players do not want to become coaches.

We want professional coaches to take up the responsibility, especially Indians who can handle the national team so that we don't have to rely on foreigners.

There was a plan to send Indian coaches abroad.

Yes, we plan to send them abroad so that they can watch and learn. We've submitted a proposal to the government.

Do you think team owners withdrawing from the HIL is a challenge?